TRAIL TIP

What's Actually Happening in That AI Chat?

Pull back the curtain. Knowing how it works makes you better at using it.

Before you open your first AI Chat in this course, here's something most people never get to see. It isn't a secret. Nobody usually takes the time to explain it.

The AI Chats in this course aren't a generic chatbot pointed at you. Each one was set up inside Blackboard for a specific moment in your learning, with a specific purpose. Here's how that works.

Start here: what is a large language model?

Tools like ChatGPT, Copilot, and the AI Chats in this course are all powered by a **large language model**: an AI system trained on enormous amounts of text, so it can predict and generate language that sounds clear and relevant.

On its own, it's a very capable generalist. It has read more text than any person ever could, and it can discuss almost any topic. But it doesn't know who you are, what class you're in, or what you're supposed to be thinking about today. Until someone gives it direction, it's just potential.

> **The AI isn't smart on its own. It's smart in response to what it's been told.**

The part nobody shows you: the setup

Before you type your first message, the AI has already read a set of instructions you don't see. Those instructions tell it how to behave in this specific chat.

For the AI Chats in this course, the instructions come from the setup in Blackboard: the type of chat, the topic, the coach's name and personality, how it should respond, and how complex its answers should be. Blackboard turns those choices into instructions the AI reads first, and they shape everything that happens next.

System prompt: the hidden instructions an AI reads before a conversation starts. Almost every AI tool has one.

Here's a simplified example of what those instructions might say for one of the chats in this course. It isn't the exact setup, but it's close to the idea.

Behind the scenes: how Coach Pathfinder gets set up

SIMPLIFIED EXAMPLE

Role	You are Coach Pathfinder, a warm, direct coach for first-year college students at OCTC.
Purpose	Help this student think through their support network and what it means to ask for help. Ask questions that help them find their own answers.
Tone	Encouraging but honest. Treat the student as capable. Don't be generic or vague.
Opening	Welcome the student and ask: "When things get hard in college, what's your instinct: push through alone, or reach out? Tell me about that."

> *"Do not write the student's answers for them. Your job is to help them find what they already know."*

Guardrails	Stay on the topic. If the student asks you to do their homework, guide them back to reflecting.

That's the whole trick. The same AI that could draft a legal brief or explain quantum physics has been given one specific job, and it does that job every time a student opens that chat.

Same AI, completely different behavior

The engine underneath is the same kind of AI used all over the world. What it does depends on what it's been told to do.

The same AI, two very different experiences

WITHOUT COURSE INSTRUCTIONS

You type: "*I'm struggling to ask for help.*"

It might give you five generic tips, suggest an app, remind you that everyone struggles, and end with an encouraging emoji.

> *Helpful in a general way. Not very useful for you, right now, in this course.*

WITH THE COURSE SETUP

You type: "*I'm struggling to ask for help.*"

Coach Pathfinder asks: "*Tell me more. Is it that you don't know who to ask, or that asking feels uncomfortable? What's underneath it?*"

> *It doesn't answer for you. It pushes you to figure out what you think. That's the design.*

Two kinds of AI Chats in this course

Socratic

Coach Pathfinder asks you questions, one at a time, to help you think something through. It won't hand you answers.

Modules 2, 8, and 9

Role-play

You work through a scenario with the AI playing a part. You do the thinking and the evaluating as the scenario unfolds.

Module 4

What this means for you

It has a job to do. The AI Chats aren't here to answer every question you have. Each one has a purpose, usually to help you think, not to think for you. If it keeps asking you questions instead of giving answers, that's not a glitch. That's the point.

Your instructor can see the conversation. After you submit, your instructor can review the whole chat. That's how you get credit, and how your instructor learns whether the activity is working. Have an honest conversation.

It can still be wrong. Even with good instructions, the AI can misunderstand you, wander off track, or say something that doesn't land. Your judgment matters. Each chat ends with a reflection question where you can say what worked and point out anything that seemed wrong or biased. That's what a critical thinker does.

Have a concern? Talk with your instructor. If you have a concern about using the AI Chats, talk with your instructor before the chat is due. That might be an accommodation, a privacy worry, or just not feeling comfortable with AI. Your instructor can work out another way for you to complete it.

HOW THE AI CHATS WORK

- They use Blackboard's AI Conversation tool, which runs on Microsoft's Azure OpenAI Service.
- According to Blackboard, your conversation isn't used to retrain the AI.
- Your chat is saved in Blackboard with your assignment, where your instructor can review it.
- The topic, the coach, and the purpose of each chat were chosen for this course. It's a course activity with a learning goal, not a generic AI product.

BE SAFE

The same rule applies here as with any AI tool: don't share other people's personal information, passwords, or anything private in the chat.

PATHFINDER TIP

Next time you use any AI tool, in this course or anywhere else, ask yourself: *what was this told to do before I showed up?* The answer shapes everything you're about to experience. That question is the beginning of AI literacy.

Now you know something most AI users never think about. AI isn't magic. It's instructions, context, and a very capable language engine pointed in a specific direction by a person with a goal. In this course, the goal is your learning. Now go have an honest conversation.
